

FEMINISM, SEX AND GENDER

UPSC PRELIMS + GS MAINS | PRIMARY HOME: GS-II CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS

Continuous core-first rail | Advanced enrichment stays subordinate to the GS core

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ORIGIN AND DATED RAIL

1755	A Discourse on the Origin of Inequality
1759-97	Mary Wollstonecraft
1759-97	Theory When Mary Wollstonecraft
1792	Vindication of the Rights of Woman
1806-73	John Stuart Mill
1807-59	Harriet Taylor
1869	The Subjection of Women
1970	The Dialectic of Sex
1971	Sexual Politics
1972	Women, Resistance and Revolution
1973	Hidden from History
1989	She continued this approach in The Past is before Us
MECHANISM	Chronology fixes what each named work actually changed, so the argument cannot slide into a vague rise-and-fall story.
TRAP / LIMIT	Sex and gender mean the same thing -> Gauba makes the distinction foundational: sex is biological, gender is cultural. (PDF pp.84-86)
ANSWER LINE	Gauba treats feminism as a protest against the inferior status assigned to women by patriarchy, not as a denial that biological differences exist. (PDF pp.84-86)

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CHAPTER SPINE, STEP BY STEP

●	Gauba starts by defining feminism as resistance to unjust female subordination produced by patriarchy. (PDF p.84)
●	He then distinguishes sex from gender so that biological difference is separated from socially assigned inferiority. (PDF pp.84-86)
●	Gender roles such as aggressiveness/dominance for men and submissiveness/expressiveness for women are treated as cultural instruments of social control. (PDF p.85)
●	Gauba argues that biological differences do not justify inferior status for women; the main causes lie in social arrangements and cultural conditioning. (PDF pp.86-87)
●	He ends by classifying feminism into liberal, radical and socialist streams. (PDF pp.88-90)
MECHANISM	The spine is the order in which the source itself develops the argument; reproducing it keeps the answer sequenced rather than listed.
TRAP / LIMIT	All feminism says women are biologically determined -> Firestone's reproductive-biology argument is one radical-feminist position, not feminism's consensus. (PDF p.89)
ANSWER LINE	Feminism: concern with the status and role of women in relation to men, combined with protest against injustice suffered because of sex. (PDF p.84)

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ILLUSTRATIONS ATTACHED TO THE CLAIMS THEY SUPPORT

Gauba's examples of girls being socialized toward obedience Gauba's examples of girls being socialized toward obedience and boys toward assertiveness show how gender roles are culturally produced. (PDF p.87)	The early rights agenda focused on education, property, The early rights agenda focused on education, property, divorce and suffrage because these exclusions had no necessary connection with female biology. (PDF pp.87-88)
A safe classroom example is to contrast biological maternity A safe classroom example is to contrast biological maternity with culturally assigned ideas that women must therefore remain outside public life.	Gauba's cited 1980 UN numerical claim and the follow-up line Gauba's cited 1980 UN numerical claim and the follow-up line saying the condition remained unchanged should never be repeated as current

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Gauba's cited 1980 UN numerical claim and the follow-up line

Gaub's cited 1980 UN numerical claim and the follow-up line saying the condition remained unchanged should never be repeated as current fact; at most they are dated book-period illustrations. (PDF p.86)

MECHANISM Examples are evidence only when the answer states what they prove and where they stop proving it.

TRAP / LIMIT If women receive equal legal rights, feminism has no further issue -> Gauba shows later feminism asking about representation, social status and unequal participation in public power. (PDF pp.91-93)

ANSWER LINE Sex vs gender: sex is natural/biological; gender is cultural/social. (PDF pp.84-86)

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COMPARISON MATRIX

Stream	Core claim	Main obstacle identified	Remedy emphasized
Liberal feminism	Women deserve equal opportunity and equal rights in all walks of life. (PDF p.88)	Formal legal, educational and professional barriers. (PDF pp.88-89)	Equal pay, representation, reform of discriminatory laws. (PDF p.88)
Radical feminism	Women's oppression is primary and cannot be reduced to some deeper system alone. (PDF p.89)	Patriarchal sexual power and reproductive dependence. (PDF p.89)	Transform sex-power relations and dismantle domination. (PDF p.89)
Socialist feminism	Women's oppression is linked both to patriarchy and capitalism. (PDF pp.89-90)	Wage labour, domestic labour and class exploitation together. (PDF pp.89-90)	Link women's liberation with broader anti-capitalist and anti-oppression struggles. (PDF p.90)

MECHANISM Running the comparison on shared axes converts a description into an adjudication.

TRAP / LIMIT Old statistics in the book can be quoted as present reality -> The 1980 UN figure and book-era representation data are historical and must not be presented as current fact. (PDF pp.86, 91-93)

ANSWER LINE Gauba's examples of girls being socialized toward obedience and boys toward assertiveness show how gender roles are culturally produced. (PDF p.87)

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EXAMINER TRAP FIREWALL

TRAP Sex and gender mean the same thing

REPAIR Gauba makes the distinction foundational: sex is biological, gender is cultural. (PDF pp.84-86)

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MECHANISM Each pair is a tested misreading followed by the exact repair the source supports.

ANSWER LINE Read the deeper companion at [Political-Theory/advanced/06_Feminism-Sex-and-Gender.md](#)

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OWNERSHIP BOUNDARIES AND CROSS-LINKS

THIS TOPIC OWNS

- Read the deeper companion at [Political-Theory/advanced/06_Feminism-Sex-and-Gender.md](#)
- Use [Political-Theory/00_Master-Framework.md](#) for the ideology matrix and anti-caricature guidance on feminism
- Use [Political-Theory/README.md](#) for the module map linking feminism to state, power, citizenship and justice
- Topic-map continuities especially matter with [Political-Theory/basic/13_Diverse-Perspectives-on-the-State.md](#) (feminist state), [Political-Theory/basic/15_Power-Authority-and-Legitimacy.md](#) (gendered power), [Political-Theory/basic/16_Citizenship-and-Its-Critiques.md](#) (feminist citizenship) and [Political-Theory/basic/20_Diverse-Perspectives-on-Justice.md](#) (feminist justice)

DELEGATED OR EXCLUDED

- For cross-syllabus support, use [Philosophy/paper-2/socio-political/Gender-Discrimination.md](#)
- For constitutional-equality application, move outward to [Polity/advanced/07_Fundamental-Rights.md](#)

MECHANISM Syllabus boundary discipline prevents a conceptual answer from being marked down as off-topic.

ANSWER LINE Ann Oakley (*Sex, Gender and Society*, 1972) is usually credited with popularising the working sex/gender terminology in sociology - sex as biological, gender as the culturally learned

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REVISION CAPSULE AND ANSWER SPINE

- Begin with feminism as protest against patriarchy. (PDF p.84)

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REVISION CAPSULE AND ANSWER SPINE

●	Begin with feminism as protest against patriarchy. (PDF p.84)
●	Define sex and gender separately and sharply. (PDF pp.84-86)
●	Use Rousseau's natural/conventional inequality distinction to show why gender hierarchy is alterable. (PDF p.86)
●	Note that biological differences do not justify inferior status. (PDF pp.86-87)
●	Classify feminism into liberal, radical and socialist streams with one thinker each. (PDF pp.88-90)
●	End by warning against using Gauba's dated numerical claims as present-day evidence. (PDF pp.86, 91-93)
MECHANISM	The capsule is the last-minute recall rail; it should be reproducible in under two minutes.
ANSWER LINE	Carole Pateman (The Sexual Contract, 1988): Claim - classical social-contract theory (Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau) silently assumes a prior "sexual contract" securing men's access to women's

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GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route	10-mark route
Distinguish sex from gender and explain why the distinction matters politically. Answer in 150 words	Why is patriarchy a political category rather than merely a description of family authority? Answer in 150 words
10-mark route	15-mark route
Compare liberal, radical, Marxist and socialist feminism as explanations of women's subordination. Answer in 150 words	Critically examine Judith Butler's account of gender performativity and the category problem it creates for feminism. Answer in 250 words
15-mark route	15-mark route
Evaluate the feminist critique of the public-private divide with reference to Carole Pateman and Susan Moller Okin. Answer in 250 words	Is feminism best understood as a project of equality, empowerment or social transformation? Discuss. Answer in 250 words
MECHANISM	Directive fidelity, not content volume, decides the band a Mains answer lands in.
ANSWER LINE	Judith Butler (Gender Trouble, 1990): gender is not a cultural coating on a stable biological sex but performative - produced through repeated, stylised acts (speech, gesture, dress

QUALIFIED VERDICT
Carole Pateman (The Sexual Contract, 1988): Claim - classical social-contract theory (Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau) silently assumes a prior "sexual contract" securing men's access to women's. Ann Oakley (Sex, Gender and Society, 1972) is usually credited with popularising the working sex/gender terminology in sociology - sex as biological, gender as the culturally learned. A high-band answer therefore names the position, names the mechanism, names the objection and then says exactly how far the claim still holds.